fact it had been a number of years since he had been in Persia, Afghanistan or India, throughout the post-war period the foreign secretary insisted that he knew best – in fact that he knew better than those officials currently in India. Curzon also possessed a 'competitive or even combative instinct', which meant that rather than remaining open-minded to alternative points of view, he was apt to see this as a personal challenge and aimed to silence those who disagreed with him.[6] This explains why he did not simply ignore the Indian government, but actually went as far as degrading its expertise as in the case of the Anglo-Persian Agreement, or mocking and belittling it as with the Caliphate issue. Indeed, Curzon made his feelings on the Indian government perfectly clear in his letter to Montagu in 1922 prior to the secretary of state's resignation. That he believed Delhi was trying to 'dictate' to London about Muslim affairs is indicative of his belligerent attitude towards the Indian government, as well as his sensitivity – boarding on paranoia – of having his authority questioned by others. Stubborn, combative and narrow-minded, Curzon was also highly ambitious. As one biographer has put it, 'The goal at which he [Curzon] ever aimed can be described compendiously as achievement'.[7] Curzon's tenure as viceroy had ended ignominiously and for a number of years afterwards he had been left out in the cold from government business. This meant that by the time Curzon had ascended to a position of authority in 1918 he was looking to rehabilitate his image. The demise of imperial Russia appeared to provide the perfect opportunity for him to make his mark on South Asia, and thus the Indian government's scepticism and constant criticism of his chosen course of action was highly inconvenient.

The Indian government's position was made worse by the fact that there were few in London who were willing to challenge Curzon when it came to South Asia. His travels and writings had given him a self-proclaimed expertise on the region which meant that others often deferred to his opinion. Curzon also frequently referred to the fact that he was an ex-viceroy whenever his advocated policies were questioned. Within the Home government Curzon's knowledge of South Asia probably was unrivalled. Even if his arguments were wrong, there were few who were in a position to dispute this with him. As one historian puts it, in the post-war period 'A prime minister who knew nothing about the East was matched by a foreign secretary who knew everything about it except how to deal with it...'[8] His